

Christian County Juvenile Drug Court

Implementation Evaluation ix Strategy #10. Cultural Competence – Create policies and procedures that are responsive to cultural differences and train personnel to be culturally competent. Findings from the participant observation, team interviews, and the focus group showed that the Christian County Juvenile Drug Court team has demonstrated cultural competence by sending team members to training conferences where cultural issues are taught. Team members also make efforts to learn about the participant's background and interact with family members in order to gain an understanding of the youth's culture. These actions reflect the team's awareness of the importance of cultural issues, help strengthen relationships between the participant and the staff, and effectively address the needs of both the participant and the family. Strategy #11. Focus on Strengths – Maintain a focus on the strengths of youth and their families during program planning and in every interaction between the court and those it serves. Findings from the participant observation, focus group, and staff/team interviews showed that the Christian County Juvenile Drug Court team focuses on the individual strengths of each participant and their family throughout the duration of the Drug Court program. As part of the initial assessment (AIA), the Drug Court team includes a "Strengths Assessment" questionnaire, which helps the participant to concentrate on his/her accomplishments and successes. This approach begins the participant's program with a strength-based perspective and prepares the participant to accept a more responsible role in the community. This strengths-based approach also aides in creating bonds between the participant and his/her family and helps the family provide support to the child during the program. Strategy #12. Family Engagement – Recognize and engage the family as a valued partner in all components of the program. Findings from the focus group, participant observation, and staff/team interviews showed that the Christian County Juvenile Drug Court program recognizes the importance of family roles and support in the treatment of the juvenile participant. Members of the Drug Court team understand that family members can influence the juvenile to make important choices throughout the duration of the program. Therefore, the team makes every effort to engage the family in all components of the program. In the Christian County program parents or other family members are required to attend and participate in court sessions. Participants and their family are also required to attend family treatment sessions. The Drug Court team also uses the initial assessment and other tools to evaluate the role of each family member and the dynamics between the family and the participant. By involving the participant's family members during the Drug Court program the participant's progress is enhanced and the family relationship is strengthened. Strategy #13. Educational Linkages – Coordinate with the school system to ensure that each participant enrolls in and attends an educational program that is appropriate to his or her needs. Findings from the focus group and staff/team interviews showed that the Christian County Juvenile Drug Court program has a strong relationship with the local school system including guidance counselors and teachers. This enables them to closely monitor the participants' attendance, grades, and teacher assessments. Because team members stay in contact with school officials they can quickly address any issues that might arise in order to best meet the needs of the participant. Each participant is required to attend school or to work toward a GED. The Drug Court also works with community resources such as day treatment, continuing education, and workforce development in order to help participants with continuing educational and vocational needs.